

food for THOUGHT

✱ **Elumalai Sarathbabu, 29**

Project Making good food accessible to students

Can-do Icon His mother Deepa Ramani, who sold idlis on the street to finance his education

Rs 13 lakh crore will be the worth of the Indian food industry by 2015



For this 29-year-old first-generation entrepreneur, success did not come easy. In the very first year of his catering business, he suffered a loss of Rs 25 lakh. He had also incurred debts worth lakhs for his education in BITS, Pilani, and IIM-Ahmedabad. Today, this son of an anganwadi worker, who used to sell idlis on the pavements of Chennai to support

the education of her children, is sitting pretty on an annual turnover of Rs 4 crore. "My mother is my first inspiration to start a food business. My experience as the mess secretary at IIM-A was the second inspiration," says Elumalai Sarathbabu, owner of Food King Catering Services.

"My aim was to get into IIM-Ahmedabad. I cleared CAT in my third attempt and went to Ahmedabad, neck deep in debt," he says. There he felt he had a good opportunity in food business. He had read in a newspaper that 30 per cent of the Indians do not get

even two meals a day. "I know what hunger is. So I wondered if I could help these people," he says. His friends helped him start the company with a capital of Rs 1 lakh. In July 2006, he started supplying tea, coffee and snacks to a company called Sys Plus in Ahmedabad. Initially he was making a loss. "I kept telling myself, I am moving in the right direction," he says.

In March 2007, he got an offer to start a unit at BITS, Pilani. For the first time, he made profits. Four months later he got the contract to feed 1,300 students of BITS, Goa. Within six months, he repaid all his debts. "We achieved a turnover of Rs 20 crore by the end of the year," he says. Today, Sarathbabu has 50 people working under him. "I want to change their lives. We support marriage and education of poor families. We are paying them more as the company is growing well," he says.

by Lakshmi Subramanian

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ELUMALAI SARATHBABU, Entrepreneur